50TH ANNIVERSARY

ENTERTAINMENT
1995-2005



PRIME-TIME ICONS Clockwise, Amitabh Bachchan on the sets of *Kaun Banega Crorepati;* stills from *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi; Shaktimaan;* and *C.I.D.*

HEMANTH PITHWA



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plenty of space already for over a decade, as the old maestros faded away from Bollywood. The Nazia Hassan generation had already star-spangled the Eighties, the guzzlers preferred ghazal to paint their soft evenings, a Qawwali storm called Nusrat had blown in from across the border, and even classical had a new cachet. But on the small screen, rubbing shoulders with Seattle grunge hollerers and hip-hop flowmasters on MTV, a batch of homegrown popstars emerged: Alisha Chinai, Lucky Ali, Shweta Shetty, Suchitra Krishnamoorthy and, with no import tariffs those days, also a certain Adnan Sami. Alisha's biggest hit was called 'Made in India', but even that was clearly a response to the enormous amounts of world culture sloshing around those days. Not to forget, its producer was that old pop meister from London, Biddu, an early self-invention in globalising India.

There was another stream that emblematised the way pop music was being conceived by then. This was bhangrapop, a bustling 16-lane highway between global cultures that vroomed back and forth across a kingdom that stretched—naturally—all the way from Bathinda to Birmingham, with a clover-leaf detour